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Gangopadhyay, 46
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connect. Anyodesh is not a mere platform. Though the group started only with sightless women, it now includes men as well. All of them are also poor.

Says Gangopadhyay, "One fine morning, watching them at work, I discovered that they follow a rule. They believe that obstruction is knowledge. They comprehend space by means of understanding that obstruction. That inspired me." Theatre, he believes, is the best shelter for the sightless as it gives them an opportunity to vent their grief. "Drama therapy has only just entered the popular theatre lexicon but it has always existed in our culture," he says.

Gangopadhyay took up zoology in Vivekananda Centenary College in North 24 Parganas, but the pull of the stage could not be resisted and he earned a post-graduate degree in drama from the Rabindrabharati University. He has given Bangla theatre at least 10 well-received plays. The Paschimanga Natya Academy recognised *Manasamongol*, directed by Gangopadhyay, as the best production of the year in 2001. Be it proscenium plays or street dramas, he has directed many big hits. Under his direction, The Blind Opera produced Tagore's *Raja* in 2005—the same play that the legendary Shombhu Mitra created history with.

Gangopadhyay's plays don't start straight-away with acting classes. They begin with a workout, followed by speech therapy, music classes and finally acting lessons. He follows an atypical technique to provide the sightless with a sense of space on the stage, using ropes and musical signals to direct the movement of the actors. But this is a behind-the-curtains story. So practised are their movements that to the audience they look like any other accomplished actors. Says Gangopadhyay, "The sightless can see, but in their own way. Our endeavour aims to create a bridge between the sightless and the rest of the society." Lamenting that no one cares about their progress, he says, "The Left Front has done nothing for them in 30 years. NGOS show sympathy only to earn profit. We are not here to show sympathy. We are here to live as human beings by helping each other."

Last year, Gangopadhyay also established the Theatre School for the Oppressed with the idea of piloting abused, poor and marginalised men and women towards a normal livelihood, as well as the district-level Theatre School for Children. The same year The Blind Opera came into being, Gangopadhyay married Dola Chakraborty, a theatre worker. Over a decade later, he and his wife are no richer. They work hard to provide a good education to their 11-year-old daughter Rai. But Gangopadhyay's family does not end there. It is a huge umbrella, under which an expanding unit takes shelter against an inclement world. ■



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